Communist Organisations, had garnered in November 1918).[175] *An account given by H.G. Wells describes the Congress's Chair, Zinoviev, and his colleagues holding an event at Baku 'at which they gathered together a quite wonderful accumulation of white, black, brown and yellow people, Asiatic costumes and astonishing weapons. They had a great assembly in which they swore undying hatred of capitalism and British imperialism'.*[176] *Zinoviev claimed that the event showed 'the living strength of our revolution', and even went so far as to call for a jihad against British imperialism.*[177]

The practical effects of the Baku Congress, in bringing about an understanding between Bolshevism and pan-Islamism were, however, limited. Instead the Congress revealed that all Zinoviev had to offer 'was empty rhetoric', rather than a well-conceived plan.[178] One report to reach British Intelligence stated that while many violent speeches were made, the general effect was spoiled by large numbers of the Muslim representatives going outside to say their prayers and that 'not the faintest notice was taken of most of the numerous speeches made, the delegates being far more interested in each other's swords and revolvers'.[179] Far from being a vehicle for open debate and discussion, the Congress consisted of a list of speakers that had 'been made beforehand and consisted only of Russian Communists', with few being allowed to speak freely: 'Several of the Mussulman orators made an attempt to speak but were not allowed to continue.'[180] One delegate described the Congress as 'a badly-acted comedy...a mere farce, having no significance for Eastern peoples, especially for Moslems'.[181] Wells himself admitted the event was 'an excursion, a pageant, a Beano. As a meeting of Asiatic proletarians it was preposterous'.[182] British Intelligence even reported that one of their agents had seen a telegram from Zinoviev to Lenin admitting that the Congress was a failure.[183] The chairman's rant against Muslim clergy, labelling them parasites and oppressors, did not go down particularly well with his audience.[184]

However, while Zinoviev and his colleagues may have been clumsy in their handling of the delegates to the Congress, as a work of propaganda the event was a huge success. As the report by British Intelligence concluded, if the delegates to the Congress were really elected by the people they claimed